

THE CURRENT BRIEFING OF

MERIDIAN

Twelve desks. One world.

THURSDAY 3 SEPTEMBER 2026



THE QUESTION UNDER THE WEEK — WHAT ACTUALLY BACKS THE PROMISE · A RESERVE, A MAKER, A MARKER, A METAL

THE WORLD

Fresh American strikes move inland, Iran answers across four borders in a night, and oil jumps five per cent to ninety-five dollars

TECHNOLOGY

Nvidia is reported to be paying up to fourteen billion for Hugging Face — the neutral hub every rival's chips download from

THE LONG READ

Hanoi tears down its gold monopoly and asks for the nation's hoard back; a generation answers by buying more, on their phones

Twelve Desks · One World

Source: Wikimedia Commons — gold bullion bars. Representative; the metal at the centre of Vietnam's Gen-Z gold rush (p21) and of a week that turned on what actually stands behind a promise.

THIS ISSUE • THE WEEKDAY BOOK

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FROM THE DESK

"In the absence of the gold standard, there is no way to protect savings from confiscation through inflation."

— Alan Greenspan, "Gold and Economic Freedom" (1966)¹

Greenspan wrote it as a young gold partisan, decades before he ran the printing press himself — and the week keeps proving the smaller point inside it: that every promise rests on something, and the something is worth checking. Singapore will only trust a private stablecoin backed one-for-one and barred from paying a cent (p5). A generation of Vietnamese, distrusting the dong, backs its savings with metal it now buys by the gram on an app (p21). A towel's promise is the length of its fibre, not the weight of its pile (p6); a firm grip promises longevity but does not confer it (p18). The week's quiet subject is the backing — the gap between the thing that is claimed and the thing that stands behind it.

THE STRIP — AT WEDNESDAY'S CLOSE

INSTRUMENT	LEVEL
VWRA (All-World)	~US\$193.4 ▼
Gold (spot)	~US\$4,355 ▼
Bitcoin	~US\$77k ▼
US 10-year	~4.79% ▲
US dollar (DXY)	~99.85 ▲
Brent crude	~US\$95 ▲
USD/JPY	~158.9 ▼
STI	~5,708 ▼

Levels around the 2–3 Sep 2026 close; ▲ / ▼ mark the move, not sentiment. Oil firmer on the Hormuz strikes; the ten-year at a two-year high and the dollar bid as the Fed leans hawkish (p14). Context, not advice.²

THE WEEK IN NUMBERS

Up to fourteen billion dollars. The reported price for Hugging Face — plus a reported billion just to keep the staff — for the open-model hub every rival's chips download from. — **p7**

One hundred per cent. The reserve a MAS-regulated stablecoin must hold against every token, segregated and redeemable at par — and it may pay the holder no interest at all. — **p5**

Eighty-four per cent. The rise in Vietnamese domestic gold since early 2025 — outpacing the world price — as a generation hedges the dong by the gram. — **p21**

A third. The lower all-cause death risk linked to the firmest grip in a study of five thousand older women — a marker of robustness, not a lever that makes it. — **p18**

SOURCES 1. Alan Greenspan, "Gold and Economic Freedom," in *The Objectivist* (1966; reprinted in Ayn Rand, *Capitalism: The Unknown Ideal*, 1967). 2. stockanalysis.com; TradingEconomics; Yahoo Finance; CoinDesk — levels around the 2–3 Sep 2026 close (see p14). Market data is context, not investment advice.

THE WORLD · IRAN & THE GULF

The Strikes Move Inland, and Iran Answers Across Four Borders in a Night

A second American round in three days hit Iran's southern coast — and a home in Sirik where a wedding was under way. Overnight, Iranian missiles fell on bases in Jordan, Bahrain, Kuwait and northern Iraq. Brent jumped five per cent to ninety-five dollars, and no capital has drawn the off-ramp.

The month's rhythm has hardened into a war. On 1 September, US Central Command announced its second round of strikes in three days on Iran's southern coast, saying it hit radar and mine-laying assets near the Strait of Hormuz after fresh Revolutionary Guard attempts to seed the channel and to fire on a US base in Jordan.¹ Trump cast it as a warning: if Tehran answered, Iran "will be hit again at a much harder and higher level," with "very little left."¹ The strikes killed at least eleven in Iran — among them, the Iranian Red Crescent said, five at a house in Kuhestak, in Sirik district, where a wedding was under way; a child was among the dead and more than fifty were hurt.²

Tehran did not confine its reply to the strait. Overnight into 2 September, Iranian missiles and drones struck American bases across the region — in Jordan, Bahrain, Kuwait and the Kurdistan region of Iraq — the widest single night of the war; Jordan said it intercepted ten of thirteen missiles that crossed its airspace.² Two US officials told Reuters there were no American casualties; Iran's claim to have killed US service members rests on state sources alone, and the desk holds it rather than repeat it as fact.² What moved unambiguously was oil: Brent settled near ninety-five dollars, up about five per cent and its firmest since late July.³

**THE GULF
READ**

**RIYADH · ARAB-ISLAMIC
STATEMENT**

An Arab-Islamic bloc — Saudi Arabia, the UAE, Qatar and others — condemned the Iranian strikes on Gulf infrastructure as something that "cannot be justified," and Riyadh warned its restraint "is not unlimited." The regional framing puts the night's blame on Tehran, not Washington.³

THE NON-ALIGNED READ

DOHA / BEIJING

Al Jazeera led with the Sirik wedding and Iran's vow of a "firm response" — an escalating two-way war, not a clean enforcement action. China's foreign ministry pressed for de-escalation, urging "an immediate ceasefire" and a return "to the track of negotiation."²

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE TRACKERS SEE

Analysts read Hormuz traffic as down roughly ninety-five per cent from a pre-war norm near a hundred and seventy-eight ships a day, with about two thousand vessels stranded and war-risk premiums nearing a tenth of a hull's value. The market's restraint is the counter-signal: a price that stops at ninety-five dollars is not one pricing a permanent closure — yet.

International Crisis Group Hormuz tracker; CNBC; The National — characterised

**THE SCEPTIC · A QUAGMIRE, OR A SLOW
SQUEEZE?**

The consensus frame is a war that "cannot be won or easily exited": the Center for American Progress notes a campaign Trump billed at four-to-five weeks is past six months, with more than fifty thousand troops deployed. The attributable counter, from an Al Jazeera opinion, argues the strategy has shifted to a patient economic strangulation "making steady progress," not the debacle critics insist on. Both cannot be right; the oil price is the only honest referee, and it has not closed the lane.⁴

Center for American Progress; Al Jazeera opinion; RAND — characterised

SOURCES 1. CNBC; NBC News; Bloomberg, 1 Sep 2026 — US CENTCOM's second strike round in three days on Iran's southern coast (radar/mine-laying assets near Hormuz) after fresh IRGC attempts on shipping and on a US base in Jordan; Trump's "much harder and higher level... very little left." 2. Al Jazeera; CNN; RTÉ; Daily Sabah; Muscat Daily, 1–2 Sep 2026 — the Sirik/Kuhestak wedding-house strike (Iranian Red Crescent: five dead incl. a child, 50+ hurt); Iran's overnight missile/drone salvo on bases in Jordan (Camp Titin), Bahrain (Sheikh Isa), Kuwait and Iraqi Kurdistan; Jordan intercepted 10 of 13; Reuters (two US officials) — no US casualties; Iran's claim of US dead single-sourced to state media, held; China MOFA de-escalation line. 3. TradingEconomics; Bloomberg; Arab News — Brent ~US\$95 (+~5% Tue), firmest since late July; Hormuz ~20% of seaborne oil; the Arab-Islamic statement ("cannot be justified"; Saudi restraint "not unlimited"). 4. Center for American Progress ("a Middle East quagmire it can neither win nor easily exit," 20 Aug); Al Jazeera opinion ("starting to pay off," 28 Aug); RAND ("a dilemma, not a debacle") — characterised.

THE WORLD • EUROPE

Germany Names Russia Over a Bomb Drone Found Beside a Ukrainian Freighter

An explosive-laden drone sat inside a secure zone at Leipzig, one of Europe's busiest cargo hubs, next to an Antonov aircraft. Berlin says the parts match Moscow's other sabotage jobs — and is closing two Russian missions in reply.

The second front of Europe's war is the quiet one, and this week it grew louder. German authorities concluded that Russia was behind an explosive-laden drone discovered on 4 August inside a secure area near the cargo runway at Leipzig/Halle airport — the base of Ukraine's Antonov Airlines and one of the continent's busiest freight hubs. The device carried military-grade explosives, sat beside a Ukrainian cargo plane, failed to detonate and was defused.¹ Interior Minister Alexander Dobrindt said the components matched "other hybrid operations conducted by Russia," and Germany is closing Russia's Bonn consulate and its Berlin cultural centre in response.¹

Brussels treated it as a threshold. Ursula von der Leyen, with NATO's Mark Rutte, framed the plot as the first Russian sabotage on EU soil tied to

explosives beside a live Ukrainian aircraft, and promised a collective response.² The pattern the desk has tracked for a year — arson, rail interference, GPS jamming — has reached a defused bomb in a working airport. What changed is attribution: Berlin will name Moscow in public, and pay a diplomatic price for it.

THE CHATTER • THE HYBRID LEDGER

Security analysts count the Leipzig device as the most kinetic entry yet in a two-year run of low-signature Russian operations across Europe — and note the target was logistics, the artery that keeps Ukraine supplied. The open question they raise is deterrence: closing a consulate is a gesture, not a cost, and no European capital has settled on what actually raises the price of a sabotage campaign run at deniable arm's length.

Defense News; Euronews; TIME — characterised

THE WORLD • SOUTH ASIA

The Himalayan Flood Toll Passes Eleven Hundred, and the Missing Are Counted in Tunnels

The disaster that opened on 26 August, when a wall of water destroyed the Rasuwagadhi border crossing and tore down some seventy-two kilometres of the Trishuli valley, is far larger than the last count carried here. Nepal has now recovered 1,114 bodies, with sixteen more dead across the border in Tibet and 546 missing there; Nepal's own missing estimate has been revised sharply upward, toward 3,900.³ Around nine hundred workers across a dozen hydropower projects are unaccounted for, with an estimated five hundred believed trapped in tunnels; nine South Korean workers are among the missing.³

SETTING THE RECORD STRAIGHT

No. 90 carried this as "469 confirmed dead, roughly 1,300 missing." That was the count at the time; it has more than doubled since, and the figures still move by the hour and by the source. The 3,900 missing is an official estimate, not a confirmed death toll — held here as what it is.³

IN BRIEF • THE WIDER DESK

Venezuela. The 25-year oil deal flagged last issue has drawn its first pushback: opposition figures and several US legislators are questioning the terms, which surfaced only after signing. The barrels, not the politics, are what the Macro Desk is watching (p14).⁴

Oil's long tail. The US Energy Information Administration says Middle East output will not return near pre-war levels until early 2027 — the number under the whole week's market story.⁴

SOURCES 1. CNN; Euronews; NPR; TIME, 1–2 Sep 2026 — German Interior Ministry / Alexander Dobrindt on the 4 Aug Leipzig/Halle explosive drone (military-grade explosive, beside a Ukrainian cargo plane, defused; two more found), components matching "other hybrid operations conducted by Russia"; closure of Russia's Bonn consulate and Berlin cultural centre; Trump's ~30-ships-a-night escort claim (unverified). 2. Euronews; PBS; CBC, 1–2 Sep 2026 — von der Leyen (with NATO's Rutte) on a collective response. 3. Al Jazeera; ABC News; NPR, 28 Aug–2 Sep 2026 — Nepal 1,114 recovered + 16 dead in Tibet, 546 missing in Tibet, Nepal missing est. ~3,900; ~900 hydropower workers missing, ~500 believed trapped, 9 South Koreans; disaster from 26 Aug (Rasuwagadhi, ~72 km of the Trishuli). Tolls shift by hour/source; 3,900 is an estimate, held. 4. TradingEconomics; US EIA — Brent context, output not near pre-war until early 2027; Venezuela deal scrutiny per wire coverage.

SINGAPORE • MONEY & RULES

A Stablecoin You Can Trust Pays You Nothing — and Is Backed to the Last Cent

MAS opened its draft law on 1 September: a regulated stablecoin must hold one dollar of high-quality reserves for every token, redeem at par, and pay no interest. It is a bet that the way to make private money trustworthy is to strip out the yield that makes it tempting.

The Monetary Authority of Singapore has decided what it wants a trustworthy stablecoin to be, and the answer is deliberately dull. On 1 September it opened a consultation on amendments to the Payment Services Act: a token carrying the MAS-regulated label must be pegged to the Singapore dollar or a G10 currency, backed 100 per cent at all times by high-quality liquid reserves in segregated accounts, and redeemable at par within a short window.¹ The consultation runs to 16 October and adds stress tests and orderly wind-down plans — the machinery of a thing designed not to break.¹

The sharp clause is the ban on yield. A regulated stablecoin may not pay interest to holders, because MAS has decided these tokens are plumbing for payments, not a deposit substitute — a line that puts Singapore alongside the United States and the EU's MiCA regime. Everything outside the label stays a digital payment token, with none of the trust the label confers.²

100%

THE RESERVE A MAS-REGULATED STABLECOIN MUST HOLD AGAINST EVERY TOKEN IN ISSUE — SEGREGATED, HIGH-QUALITY, REDEEMABLE AT PAR, AND EARNING THE HOLDER NOTHING¹

THE CHATTER • PAYMENTS, NOT SAVINGS

The industry read is that Singapore has chosen the "boring is the feature" path: by forbidding yield, MAS removes the mechanism by which a stablecoin quietly becomes an unlicensed bank — the trap that felled offshore issuers. The grumble is that the no-interest rule cedes the retail-savings use case to the very banks the technology was meant to route around.

CoinDesk; Business Times; TechNode — characterised

THE SCEPTIC • A LABEL IS ONLY AS GOOD AS ITS AUDIT

A 100-per-cent reserve is a promise about what sits in an account, and the history of stablecoins is a history of reserves that turned out to be commercial paper, affiliated loans, or air. The rule is right; the open question is enforcement. "Backed at all times" is only ever as strong as the last time someone counted.

Prior stablecoin reserve disclosures; analyst commentary — characterised

SINGAPORE • ONLINE SAFETY

Age Checks Get Teeth, and a Homegrown Forum Joins the Regulated Six

The teen-safety plan the desk flagged last issue now has specifics. Minister Josephine Teo has said age assurance will be made mandatory — platforms must verify age, not trust a self-declared birthday that is "easily circumvented." Under-13s would be barred; 13-to-17s kept only with an "age-appropriate

experience"; non-compliant platforms face a minimum age pushed toward 18.³ The first six "designated services" name the global giants — and, tellingly, HardwareZone, the local forum. Autoplay would default off, with a possible daily limit; legislation is targeted for early 2027.³

IN BRIEF • AROUND THE ISLAND

An 11-year gap closes. PM Lawrence Wong was in Bangkok on 2 September for the first Singapore-Thailand Leaders' Retreat since 2015, agreeing to deepen cooperation on energy and food security, digital trade and defence.⁴

SOURCES 1. MAS media release, "MAS Consults on Legislative Amendments to Implement Stablecoin Regulatory Framework" (consultation P015-2026), 1 Sep 2026; Business Times; CNA — SGD/G10 peg, 100% segregated high-quality reserves, redemption at par, no interest, stress tests + wind-down plans, closes 16 Oct 2026. 2. CoinDesk ("bans yield and mandates 100% reserves," 1 Sep 2026); TechNode Global — jointly issued and recognised foreign stablecoins; non-regulated tokens treated as Digital Payment Tokens. 3. Mothership; AsiaOne/ST, 28–31 Aug 2026; MDDI parliamentary reply — mandatory age assurance; under-13 barred, 13–17 conditional, non-compliant platforms toward age 18; six designated services incl. HardwareZone; autoplay-off default + possible daily limit; legislation early 2027. No fixed daily-hours figure has been set — reported "2-hour cap/curfew" specifics attach to overseas examples, not confirmed SG rules. 4. AsiaOne; Bangkok Post (SG-Thailand Leaders' Retreat, 2 Sep 2026, first since 2015); HDB/MND — BTO income ceiling S\$16k/S\$8k from 24 Aug, Nov exercise ~7,960 flats, HFE by 25 Sep.

THE ATELIER • BATH & HAND TOWELS

The Grail Towel Is the Wrong Towel for a Singapore Bathroom

A towel is decided by the length of the cotton fibre, not the weight of the pile — and in a humid bathroom the plush seven-hundred-gram trophy is the one that goes sour. Buy the long-staple mid-weight that dries by evening, and let the grail stay in the showroom.

Judge a towel from the fibre up. The ceiling is set by cotton staple length: longer fibres spin into finer, stronger yarn that pills less and feels soft without help, running from short-staple upland up to extra-long Egyptian Giza and American Supima. The first trap is the label. "Egyptian cotton" is a marketing phrase, not a standard — the Cotton Egypt Association reckons up to ninety per cent of goods sold under the name are not genuine, and the 2016 Welspun affair proved it is not policed.¹ The word is worth nothing; a named Giza grade, or Supima's licence, is worth something.

Two more mechanisms decide feel. Zero-twist towels, held together by a thread that dissolves in the first wash, are extraordinarily soft and fast-drying but shorter-lived; tightly twisted pile is the durability play. And GSM — grams per square metre — measures quantity, not quality: four to six hundred is the everyday sweet spot, six to nine hundred is spa-plush and slow to dry, and a five-hundred-gram combed long-staple towel beats a six-hundred-and-fifty-gram carded one on both counts.²

~1/2

A WAFFLE TOWEL'S DRYING TIME VERSUS PLUSH TERRY — WHICH IS WHY THE HUMID-BATHROOM PICK IS A MID-WEIGHT WAFFLE OR JAPANESE GAUZE, NOT THE GRAIL²

The makers, by tier. The entry of quality — Costco's Charisma, Brooklinen's Turkish Super-Plush, at fifteen to thirty-five dollars — is already most of the job. The sweet spot, forty-five to seventy, buys verified fibre: Sferra's Bello (seven hundred grams, Portugal, about forty-two dollars) and the Singapore answer, Onsen's Supima waffle at fifty-nine, dry in two to four hours.³ The grail, Abyss & Habidecor's Super Pile, is undercut by the white-label truth: Portugal is the shared factory floor, and the Bello is the same terry at a third less. Japan's Imabari mark is

SOURCES 1. Cotton Egypt Association; Statesman; classaction.org — up to ~90% of "Egyptian cotton" goods not genuine; the 2016 Welspun/Target DNA-test scandal; ELS Giza / Supima vs long-staple Turkish/Aegean vs upland. 2. Wove; Rifz; Velara/Matteola — zero-twist (soft/fast-dry, less durable) vs twisted; GSM bands; waffle dries ~half the time; a 500 GSM combed towel beats a 650 GSM carded one. 3. Fine Linens; FlandB "Towels of Portugal"; Onsen/CNN Underscored; Wirecutter — Abyss Super Pile (Giza 70, ~\$110–135), Sferra Bello (700 GSM Portugal, ~\$42), Kontex (Imabari), Onsen Supima waffle (~\$59, dries 2–4 h), Brooklinen (~\$24–35), Costco Charisma (~\$40–60). Prices indicative (USD). 4. Imabari Towel Association; JapanObjects — the Imabari absorbency test (5-second sink, new and after 3 washes); Ikeuchi "Air." SG: Takashimaya (Abyss), Tangs/Uchino SG, Weavve, Oak & Sand (Imabari/TENCEL), Lazada/Shopee/Amazon SG. Care: no fabric softener; ½-cup vinegar rinse; warm wash; ~10-year life.

the one label you trust on sight — it certifies absorbency by test.⁴

THE CHATTER • WHAT THE ENDGAME ACTUALLY IS

Cross-source rankings crown Abyss & Habidecor for plush terry — the connoisseur's trophy. But the community that lives in humid bathrooms votes differently: reddit's buy-it-for-life and quick-dry threads keep landing on the Onsen waffle as the anti-musty endgame, the same waffle Wirecutter picks. Two endgames — one for a dry showroom, one for a wet climate.

cottonwithlove / everlayer rankings; r/BuyItForLife; Wirecutter — characterised

THE SCEPTIC • THE HOTEL TAX AND THE GSM TRICK

Two pieces of theatre. GSM inflation: a heavier towel is not a better one, and in Singapore it is a worse one — it stays damp and sours, so the number the marketing pushes is the one the climate punishes. And the hotel markup: Frette lists towels at a hundred and ten to a hundred and sixty-five dollars while the same mills supply cheaper labels. Diminishing returns bite around fifty dollars of genuine long-staple cotton.

Frette / hotel-shop pricing; Cotton Egypt Association; Wirecutter — characterised

NEXT ON THE BENCH — YOU PICK THE CATEGORY

Cashmere knitwear — grade, ply and fibre length decoded, and where the pilling-versus-price line sits behind "100% cashmere."

Wristwatch straps — shell cordovan versus calf versus rubber, the strap-makers by name, and the small-money upgrade a watch reader feels.

Fine stationery & paper — Tomoe River, Midori and the mill science of GSM, sizing and feathering; the good ream, bought once.

TECHNOLOGY · THE DISTRIBUTION LAYER

Nvidia Reportedly Bids Up to Fourteen Billion for the Hub Everyone Downloads From

The figure has risen from thirteen billion to about fourteen in a week, with a reported billion just to keep the staff — and still no signature. Owning Hugging Face would let Nvidia hold the neutral shelf that every rival's chips reach for their models.

The story the desk flagged as a rumour last issue has grown, not resolved. Bloomberg reported on 2 September that Nvidia is nearing a deal for Hugging Face — the open-model repository that is, in effect, the neutral shelf from which every chipmaker's silicon downloads its weights — at about fourteen billion dollars, up from the twelve-point-nine first reported in late August, with talk of an agreement "as soon as this week" and a reported billion-dollar package just to retain the staff.¹ As this issue closed there was still no announcement, no filing and no confirmation from either company; it could yet fall through, and the desk keeps the flag on it.¹ The logic, if it is real, is about the backing under the whole ecosystem: as OpenAI and Anthropic design their own inference chips to escape Nvidia's grip, owning the distribution layer hedges the moat that the chips themselves no longer guarantee.

The escape attempt has its own hard numbers now. At Hot Chips on 25 August, OpenAI presented the first real figures for Jalapeño, its custom inference chip co-designed with Broadcom: two hundred and sixteen gigabytes of HBM4, up to roughly thirteen MXFP4 petaflops, about seven hundred watts, and — by OpenAI's own account — one-and-a-half to nearly two times the work per watt of Nvidia's Blackwell-class parts, at up to three-and-a-half times lower latency.² It deploys in "very small volumes" late this year. Read the metric before the headline: the gains are per watt, a seven-hundred-watt chip measured against parts rated at twelve to fourteen hundred — the comparison that flatters the cooler chip. There is no MLPerf submission, no third-party latency test,

no disclosed process node. The only numbers are the vendor's.²

~\$14B

THE REPORTED PRICE FOR HUGGING FACE — UP FROM \$12.9B A WEEK EARLIER — PLUS A REPORTED ~\$1B JUST TO KEEP THE STAFF. NO FILING, NO CONFIRMATION AS OF 3 SEP¹

THE CHATTER · THE NEUTRALITY PROBLEM

The developer read, via The New Stack, is that Hugging Face's whole value is that it belongs to no chipmaker: an Nvidia-owned hub raises the fear of which quant formats get first-class curation and how fast AMD's MI400 or Intel's Gaudi get support. The counter, argued in the same coverage, is that model weights carry their own licences and can be mirrored anywhere, and that the core libraries — transformers, diffusers — are Apache-licensed and forkable. A hub can be bought; an open licence cannot be un-signed.

The New Stack; r/LocalLLaMA; Hacker News — characterised

THE SCEPTIC · A DRAFT RULE POINTS AT SINGAPORE

The part of this that lands closest to home is not a chip but a loophole. US Commerce is drafting a rule to stop Chinese AI firms from *renting* Nvidia compute through data centres in third countries — with Singapore and Thailand named — that sit outside the direct export curbs; a draft could reach industry as soon as this month. It is the successor to the withdrawn tiered "AI Diffusion Rule," narrowed from the physical chip to the remote-access account. It is reporting, not law — but it is the shape of where the controls go next, and Singapore is on the map.³

Tom's Hardware; aiweekly.co; Asia Times — characterised

SOURCES 1. Bloomberg, "Nvidia Nears \$14 Billion Hugging Face Deal This Week," 2 Sep 2026; CNBC (27 Aug); The Information (26 Aug, originator); Fortune; Quartz — price risen from \$12.9B to ~\$14B, reported ~\$1B retention, deal "as soon as this week"; no company confirmation or filing as of 3 Sep — reported/unsigned, flagged. Strategic read: distribution-layer hedge as OpenAI/Anthropic build custom silicon. 2. TechCrunch; The Register; Tom's Hardware, 25 Aug 2026 (Hot Chips) — OpenAI/Broadcom "Jalapeño": 216 GB HBM4, ~13.4 MXFP4 PFLOPS, ~700 W; OpenAI's own figures 1.5–1.9× work/watt and 1.7–3.6× lower latency vs Blackwell-class; "very small volumes" late 2026. Sceptic: per-watt (700 W vs 1,200–1,400 W comparators), no MLPerf/independent test, no disclosed node — vendor numbers only. Primary: openai.com Jalapeño post. 3. Tom's Hardware; aiweekly.co; Asia Times, Aug 2026 — US Commerce/BIS draft rule on the "remote-access" loophole via data centres in Singapore and Thailand; successor to the withdrawn AI Diffusion Rule (Singapore was Tier 2). Pre-decisional draft — reporting, not law.

THE HOME LAB · WHAT ACTUALLY FITS

Two Trillion-Class Models Dropped in a Day. The One That Runs Is the Small One.

On 28 August the open-weight headlines were two giants that fit no desk. The story for a single graphics card is quieter and older by two weeks — a twenty-seven-billion-parameter model that lands in seventeen gigabytes and answers at reading speed.

The last week of August produced two "open weights!" banners on the same day, and both are theatre for anyone with a desk rather than a data centre. Z.ai released GLM-5.3 — seven hundred and forty-four billion parameters, forty billion active — under a bespoke licence that the community immediately griped is not MIT; even at four-bit it is roughly three hundred and seventy gigabytes of weights, an eight-GPU job.¹ Tencent's Hunyuan preview, the same day, is larger still at seven hundred and seventy billion. The honest read is that among machines you can actually own, these fit only a fully specified five-hundred-and-twelve-gigabyte Mac Studio — and even then they crawl, because memory bandwidth, not parameter count, sets the speed at which tokens come out.¹

The model that matters for a home lab is Alibaba's Qwen3.8-27B, released two weeks earlier under a real Apache-2.0 licence: twenty-seven billion dense parameters, natively multimodal, with a context window that runs to a quarter-million tokens and beyond.² The arithmetic is the point. Its four-bit GGUF build is about seventeen gigabytes — it loads on a single twenty-four-gigabyte card, a used RTX 3090 or a 4090, at tens of thousands of tokens of context and roughly twenty-five tokens a second; the eight-bit build wants forty-eight gigabytes, and full precision about fifty-four.² One reviewer's warning stands: left alone, it "defaults to wildly overthinking," so it earns its keep with a reasoning budget set low. This is the shape of the local frontier — not the trillion-parameter banner, but the twenty-seven-billion model that answers on one card at reading speed.

~17 GB

THE FOUR-BIT QWEN3.8-27B ON DISK — A SINGLE 24 GB CARD RUNS IT; THE DAY'S 744-BILLION HEADLINE NEEDS EIGHT GPUS TO LOAD AT ALL²

THE CHATTER · CAPACITY IS NOT SPEED

The home-lab boards spent the week on a hardware question, not a model one. AMD's Ryzen AI "Halo" desktop — a Ryzen AI Max+ 395 with a hundred and twenty-eight gigabytes of unified memory — lists around four thousand dollars, undercutting Nvidia's DGX Spark by roughly seven hundred and adding Windows. The reality check the community keeps posting: unified-memory boxes buy the capacity to load a big model, not the bandwidth to serve it fast. On a hundred-and-twenty-billion model the Spark does about thirty-nine tokens a second; three used RTX 3090s do about a hundred and twenty-four. Bandwidth is the number to read.

Tom's Hardware; r/LocalLLaMA; ServeTheHome — characterised

THE SCEPTIC · "OPEN" IS NOT THE SAME AS "YOURS TO RUN"

The word doing the heavy lifting in the week's headlines is "open," and it is being stretched. A 744-billion-parameter model whose weights you can download but only run on an eight-card rig is open the way a cathedral is open — you may look, you may not move in. Add the licence that isn't MIT, and the practical freedom shrinks further. The models a person can actually own, modify and run offline still top out around twenty-seven to thirty billion parameters; the trillion-class releases are press events for people who rent compute, not own it.

r/LocalLLaMA licence threads; digitalapplied; kingy.ai — characterised

SOURCES 1. Z.ai / vLLM (X), 28 Aug 2026; digitalapplied; kingy.ai — GLM-5.3 744B total / 40B active MoE, bespoke (non-MIT) licence, ~370 GB at 4-bit (~8-GPU rig); Tencent Hunyuan preview 770B total / 49B active, same day. Fits only a maxed 512 GB Mac Studio among "desk" machines, and slowly (bandwidth-bound). Param/quant sizes corroborated across ≥2 outlets; spot-check GGUF byte sizes on the model card before relying on them. 2. Alibaba Qwen, 14 Aug 2026 (Apache-2.0); DataNorth AI; kingy.ai; Simon Willison ("defaults to wildly overthinking," 16 Aug 2026) — Qwen3.8-27B, 27B dense, natively multimodal, 262,144-token context (extends toward 1M); Q4_K_M GGUF ~16.8 GB on a single 24 GB card (~65K ctx, ~25 tok/s; ~24.5 tok/s on Ryzen AI Max+ 395), Q8 ~28-30 GB (48 GB card), BF16 ~54 GB. AMD Ryzen AI "Halo" ~US\$3,999 (Ryzen AI Max+ 395, 128 GB unified) vs Nvidia DGX Spark ~US\$4,699; DGX Spark ~38.6 tok/s vs ~124 tok/s on 3× RTX 3090 (gpt-oss-120B) — capacity vs bandwidth. Ollama v0.33.x (21-27 Aug) added Claude Desktop as a first-class local target.

THE KIT · WEARABLES

The Glasses Whose Whole Pitch Is What They Left Out

RayNeo's iO ships tomorrow at four hundred and seventy-nine dollars — no camera, no speaker, just a monochrome display only the wearer can see. It undercuts the reader's own Even Realities G2 by a hundred and twenty, and answers the question everyone asks the Meta glasses: is that thing filming me?

Last issue the desk noted that RayNeo's iO had a launch but no reviews. It now has a price and a date, if not yet a verdict. Announced at IFA Berlin on 21 August and on sale from 4 September at four hundred and seventy-nine dollars, the iO is a heads-up display built around a subtraction: no camera, no speaker. It shows green monochrome text on a waveguide RayNeo rates at ninety-seven per cent transparency and up to thirteen hundred nits — bright outdoors, invisible to the person across the table.¹ At thirty-three grams it hears through a four-microphone array and a bone-conduction sensor, driving live captions, translation the maker claims across fifty-five languages, a teleprompter and notifications. The forty-eight-hour battery is the vendor's figure, and shipping-unit reviews have not landed.¹

The interesting move is the omission. The objection that follows Meta's camera-equipped Ray-Bans — the person opposite wondering whether they are being recorded — is designed out here, because there is nothing to record with. It is a narrow tool: captions, translation, a prompter, alerts. But it is a hundred and twenty dollars under the Even Realities G2 the desk led with last week, from a TCL-backed maker priced to fight. The reader's rule applies unbent — wait for a shipping-unit review — but the design thesis is sound: sometimes the feature is the thing you refuse to add.²

33 g

THE RAYNEO IO, CAMERA-FREE AND SPEAKER-FREE — A HUD WHOSE SELLING POINT IS THE SENSOR IT DOESN'T CARRY¹

THE CHATTER · THE NO-CAMERA BET

Across the smart-glasses boards and the IFA hand-
ons, the framing is consistent: the no-camera design reads as a deliberate answer to the surveillance unease around Meta's Ray-Bans, and RayNeo's earlier hardware has a warm value reputation. The caution is uniform too — everyone is working from previews, not shipping units.

r/smartglasses; Android Central; Digital Trends — characterised

THE KIT · STILL DEVELOPING

Ricoh Confirms the GR the Street Shooters Actually Wanted

Ricoh GR IVx. A 27 August development

announcement confirmed an "x" variant of the GR IV compact with an all-new 40 mm-equivalent f/2.8 lens — the "nifty forty" close to natural central vision — on the same 26-megapixel APS-C sensor. No confirmed price (the GR IV sits near US\$1,599), launch "Winter 2026 or later." A notice, not a review — and the GR line has a chronic stock problem.³

THE SCEPTIC · A SECOND PAIR, NOT A FIRST ONE

Strip the launch language and the iO does a handful of things: captions, translation, prompting, alerts. That is a second, single-purpose pair of glasses, not a computer for your face — and the forty-eight-hour battery is a marketing number until someone measures it. The logo tax is genuinely low here; the risk is buying an unproven pair for a use-case a phone already half-covers. On the Ricoh, "development announcement" is the industry's word for "not yet real."

Even Realities G2 comparison; DPReview — characterised

SOURCES 1. PR Newswire, "RayNeo Expands Consumer AR Lineup — RayNeo iO & GT Series," 21 Aug 2026; The Gadgeteer; GSMArena; MobileSyrup, 21 Aug 2026 — RayNeo iO US\$479 (US\$529 with charging case), on sale 4 Sep 2026, camera-free/speaker-free, green monochrome waveguide ~97% transparency / up to 1,300 nits, 33 g, 4-mic array + bone-conduction, live captions/translation (~55 languages, maker claim), teleprompter; 48 h battery is a vendor figure; full independent reviews not yet landed. 2. Android Central; Digital Trends; r/smartglasses — no-camera design as an answer to Meta Ray-Ban surveillance unease; iO undercuts Even Realities G2 (US\$599, No.90). 3. Ricoh Imaging development news (ricohgr.eu), 27 Aug 2026; DPReview, "Ricoh confirms 'x' version of the GR IV" — GR IVx, new 40 mm-equiv f/2.8, 26 MP APS-C BSI, IBIS; no confirmed price (GR IV ~US\$1,599), launch "Winter 2026 or later." Development announcement only — too new to judge.

THE GOOD LIFE • WATCHES

Omega Brings Back the Speedmaster a Generation Started On

The redesigned 38-millimetre Speedmaster ditches the oval subdials everyone quietly hated and puts a Co-Axial chronometer movement in an automatic chronograph from sixty-five hundred dollars — the spiritual heir to the old Reduced, and this time the reviews have actually landed.

Every so often a watch's news is a correction of an old mistake, and this is one. Omega has redesigned the 38-millimetre Speedmaster across seven references, and the headline is what has gone: the polarising oval subdials are replaced by round ones. Under them sits the Co-Axial Calibre 3330 — a column-wheel automatic chronograph with a silicon balance spring and a COSC rating, about fifty-two hours of reserve — in a steel case to a hundred metres.¹ Steel models start at sixty-five hundred dollars and climb to around seven thousand for the ceramic-bezel white dial; a Milano Cortina 2026 Olympic edition arrived alongside it, Omega being the Games' timekeeper.¹

What makes this worth attention is that it is the automatic Speedmaster a whole generation started on — the successor to the 1988-to-2010s "Reduced" — brought back at a sane size with a modern movement, and, unusually for this desk, with the reviews already in.¹ The honest tension enthusiasts keep raising: at sixty-five hundred it sits within a thousand dollars of a hand-wound Hesalite Moonwatch — the one with the space heritage. This is the everyday automatic; that is the icon. The wrist and the heart pull in different directions.²

The news is what's gone: the oval subdials a generation quietly hated, replaced by round ones and a chronometer movement.

\$6,500

THE STEEL SPEEDMASTER 38'S STARTING PRICE — ABOUT \$200 OVER THE OUTGOING MODEL, AND WITHIN ~\$1,000 OF THE HESALITE MOONWATCH²

THE CHATTER • RELIEF, WITH A CAVEAT

On Omega Forums and in the review comments the reception is warm — a smaller, affordable automatic Speedy is back, and the ovals are gone. The recurring gripe is the price gap: sixty-five hundred sits uncomfortably close to the Hesalite Moonwatch at around seven thousand. Nobody is calling it a logo-tax scandal; it is a fairly priced Co-Axial chronometer chronograph.

Omega Forums; Fratello / Worn & Wound comments — characterised

THE GOOD LIFE • AUDIO

Hegel's One-Box Answer, Shipping Now

Hegel H200. The Norwegian maker's new integrated amplifier — a hundred and fifty watts a

channel of Class-AB with an internal DAC and network streaming — began shipping in late August at US\$4,995. Reviewers (SoundStage!, The Absolute Sound, Darko) read it as a one-box near-endgame that "punches above its price." Buy it for the amplifier; the streaming brains will date faster than the power section.³

THE SCEPTIC • CLOSE ENOUGH TO THE ICON TO HURT

The Speedmaster 38 wears none of the Moonwatch's space heritage, and its price is close enough that the rational case and the emotional one diverge — heart says Moonwatch, wrist says 38. On the Hegel, "endgame" is the reviewer's word, not physics: its DAC and streaming will age faster than the amp, which is the part worth the money.

Omega Forums; SoundStage! Network — characterised

SOURCES 1. Omega — Speedmaster 38 mm collection (omegawatches.com); Worn & Wound; Fratello ("A New Speedmaster Reduced?"); Oracle of Time; Gear Patrol; The Calibrated Wrist, Aug 2026 — 7 refs, round subdials replace ovals, Co-Axial Cal. 3330 (3332 on date), Si14 balance spring, COSC, 4 Hz, ~52 h; 38 mm steel, 100 m WR; from US\$6,500 (— ~\$7,100 white/ceramic; two-tone \$11,700; diamond-set \$12,300–13,100), ~\$200 over the outgoing model; Milano Cortina 2026 Olympic edition alongside. Reviews landed. 2. Fratello; Omega Forums — the Speedmaster 38 vs the Hesalite Moonwatch (~US\$7,000) debate; "Speedmaster Reduced" lineage 1988–2010s. 3. Hegel via HiFi Pig / Darko.audio launch coverage; SoundStage! Network; The Absolute Sound (TAS 211); Stereonet, Aug 2026 — H200 integrated amp, 150 W/ch Class AB (to 2 Ω), internal DAC + network streaming + USB, SoundEngine2; US\$4,995 / €3,995 / £3,500, shipping late Aug 2026; "punches above price."

SCREEN & SOUND · VENICE

Danny Boyle Opens Venice With the Making of a Tabloid

"Ink" dramatises Rupert Murdoch's 1969 purchase of The Sun and the editor who remade it into Britain's best-seller. The premiere drew a five-minute standing ovation and the year's first "masterpiece" — and a montage that runs the line straight from 1969 to Trump and Musk.

The 83rd Venice Film Festival opened on 2 September with Danny Boyle's *Ink*, James Graham's adaptation of his own 2017 stage play about the machinery behind a newspaper. The subject is Rupert Murdoch's 1969 purchase of *The Sun* and his hiring of editor Larry Lamb to remake it into Britain's best-selling tabloid — Jack O'Connell as Lamb, Guy Pearce as Murdoch, Claire Foy in support. The premiere drew a four-to-five-minute standing ovation, and Boyle, who called it "the oddest film that's ever opened Venice," closes on a montage tying the 1969 launch to Trump and Musk: how we got here now.¹

The early notices are strong and thin at once. Metacritic sits at eighty on about eleven reviews, Rotten Tomatoes at ninety-two per cent on a dozen; *Vulture*'s Bilge Ebiri called it "Danny Boyle's best film in decades... it might also be a masterpiece," while *The Guardian* was cooler at three stars, calling it "lurid," and *IndieWire* graded it a B — "vividly directed if overcooked."¹ The desk's honest note: a dozen festival reviews is a thin base, and a Golden Lion is not decided until the 12th. It reaches audiences on Netflix — US cinemas on 11 December, streaming 8 January — after a short exclusive theatrical window.¹

~170k

FIRST-WEEK UNITS FOR KATSEYE'S 14-MINUTE EP — THE BIGGEST GIRL-GROUP DEBUT SINCE 2008, AHEAD OF A 91-METACRITIC ALBUM²

THE CHATTER · THE OVATION TRAP

Film Twitter and Letterboxd skew enthusiastic, led by Ebiri's "masterpiece" line — but audience volume is thin before release, so treat the "best in decades" chorus as critic-driven. The recurring knock is that Boyle's frenetic cutting can tire, and the 1969-to-now framing lands as on-the-nose polemic. Pearce noted Murdoch is reportedly "very happy" he is being played by him — a genial response to a film that ends by linking his tabloid to the present.

Vulture; The Hollywood Reporter; Variety — characterised

SCREEN & SOUND · CHARTS

A Fourteen-Minute EP Beats a Six-Year Comeback to Number One

Phoebe Bridgers, "Lost Weekend." Her first solo album since 2020 landed to near-universal acclaim

— Metacritic 91 — and debuted at No. 2 on the *Billboard* 200. It was kept off the top by **KATSEYE's "WILD,"** a five-track, roughly fourteen-minute EP that opened at No. 1 with about a hundred and seventy thousand units — the biggest girl-group debut since Danity Kane in 2008. Critics split from the charts hard: *Pitchfork* gave *WILD* a 4.5, "another perfectly hollow pop record."²

THE SCEPTIC · OVATIONS AND UNITS BOTH LIE

A Venice standing ovation is an unreliable instrument — the black-tie house claps for everyone, and its length forecasts an Oscar run about as well as a coin. *Ink* may be very good; a dozen reviews cannot yet say. And on the charts, units are not quality: a fourteen-minute EP driven by physical and bundle sales outsold a ninety-one-Metacritic album made over six years. Both numbers measure attention, not worth.

Album of the Year user aggregate; Billboard; Variety — characterised

SOURCES 1. Variety review of "Ink," 2 Sep 2026; Metacritic (movie/*Ink*, ~80 on ~11 reviews); Netflix Tudum + Variety release report (US cinemas 11 Dec 2026, streaming 8 Jan 2027); La Biennale opening-film announcement — 83rd Venice Film Festival (2–12 Sep 2026, jury pres. Maggie Gyllenhaal); Danny Boyle's "Ink," James Graham adaptation of Murdoch's 1969 *Sun* purchase + editor Larry Lamb; Jack O'Connell, Guy Pearce, Claire Foy; 4–5-min ovation; *Vulture* ("masterpiece"), *Guardian* (3★, "lurid"), *IndieWire* (B). Early/thin review base — flagged; Golden Lion awarded ~12 Sep. 2. Variety chart report, 24 Aug 2026; *Billboard* chart-beat; *Rolling Stone* + Metacritic album page — Phoebe Bridgers "Lost Weekend" (MC 91) debuts No. 2; KATSEYE "WILD" (5 tracks, ~14 min) No. 1 with ~170,000 units, biggest girl-group debut since Danity Kane 2008; *Pitchfork* 4.5/10.

THE FAMILY DESK • THE PHONE QUESTION

The Year the Rules Around Her Phone Were Redrawn

She starts Secondary 1 in a school where phones are locked away all day, and turns 13 into platforms being forced to check her age. The research says the lever that matters most may not be whether she has an account, but how old she is when she starts.

Two things landed this year that change the ground under a twelve-year-old's phone, and they arrive as she starts secondary school. Since January, Singapore's secondary students may not use smartphones or smartwatches during the entire school day — not just lessons but recess, CCA and enrichment — devices in lockers or bags, an extension of the primary-school rule from the year before.¹ And the social-media safeguards the news desk covers this issue (p5) put a date on the account question: platforms will be required to verify age, under-13s barred, thirteen-to-seventeens kept only where the experience is age-appropriate, with autoplay off by default and a possible daily limit — legislation targeted for early 2027.¹ The practical effect for a parent is cover: the school day is now phone-free by national rule, which quietly removes the "everyone's on it at recess" pressure and lets home norms match.

The freshest research sharpens where to spend the effort. A University of New South Wales study of three hundred and sixty-five Australian adolescents aged ten to fifteen, published in JAMA Network Open, found that those who began using social media younger reported more anxiety and depression symptoms — and that the average age of first use was eleven, two years under the platforms' own stated minimum.² The authors' framing is that delaying first exposure may protect mental health more than policing account status once it exists. A companion Registered Report in Nature Human Behaviour, on more than three thousand UK teens, complicates the panic usefully: children already carrying clinical-level conditions use social media differently — more

comparison, less self-control, mood swinging on likes — so the harm is concentrated, not uniform.³

age 11

THE AVERAGE AGE OF FIRST SOCIAL-MEDIA USE IN THE UNSW STUDY — TWO YEARS BELOW THE PLATFORMS' STATED MINIMUM, AND THE NUMBER THAT MAKES THE YEAR AHEAD THE DECISION POINT²

THE CHATTER • WHAT THE SG PARENTS ARE ACTUALLY DEBATING

On KiasuParents the live argument is not whether to limit but when to give the first phone at all — a recurring camp holds out for Secondary or age fourteen, and parents swap notes on the "dummy phone" workaround, where a child surrenders a decoy and keeps the real one. Sec 1 parents are forming class chat groups this month. Teachers, reported via NIE, note students still outsmart the rules — hidden devices, decoys — and that policing recess is a manpower problem. The mood is pro-restriction, sceptical about enforcement.

KiasuParents; NIE/NTU reporting — characterised

THE SCEPTIC • THE CHECKS DON'T RELIABLY WORK

Before treating age assurance as the fix, note what it can't do. Facial age-estimation has misclassified eleven-year-olds as adults; age gates are bypassed with VPNs, a borrowed birthday, or a sibling's account — and the UK and Australian evidence suggests weak checks, not clever teenagers, are the real hole. Researchers writing in The Diplomat argue that a tiered age ban is a blunter instrument than "supported autonomy" — media literacy, platform accountability, and a parent in the room. The rule buys time; it does not raise a child.⁴

BiometricUpdate; The Diplomat — characterised

SOURCES 1. MOE (announced 30 Nov 2025; in force Jan 2026) via The Star ASEAN+; AsiaOne; Mothership — secondary students bar phones and smartwatches the full school day. MDDI social-media safeguards (see p5): mandatory age assurance, under-13 barred, 13–17 conditional, autoplay-off default + possible daily limit, legislation targeted early 2027. Dates are "targeted"; treat as intentions. 2. UNSW Sydney / JAMA Network Open, reported Aug 2026, via SciMex; MedicalXpress — survey of 365 Australian adolescents aged 10–15; younger first use associated with more anxiety/depression symptoms; average age of first use 11. Correlational; modest, non-SG sample — held as reported. 3. Nature Human Behaviour Registered Report, 2025 (nature.com s41562-025-02134-4); ScienceDaily 5 May 2025 — UK sample n=3,340, ages 11–19; teens with clinical-level conditions use social media differently (more comparison, less self-control). 4. BiometricUpdate, Aug 2026 (age-estimation misclassification; VPN/borrowed-account bypass); The Diplomat, Jul 2026 ("supported autonomy" vs a tiered ban). General guidance for parents, not medical advice.

THE FAMILY DESK · BODY & SLEEP

Two Risks You Can't Change, and the One Lever You Can

Puberty's timing and a girl's body image travel together — but most of the link runs through weight, not fate. And the habit that shows up hardest in girls, not boys, is the one most under a parent's hand: sleep.

Two findings worth a parent's attention this year sit either side of a useful line — what can be changed and what cannot. On the first: a BMJ Open analysis of the long-running ALSPAC cohort, some six and a half thousand young people, found that in girls an earlier first period was associated with higher body dissatisfaction at fourteen — but that the effect was substantially explained by body mass index, not by pubertal timing as destiny.¹ That is a complication of the simple early-puberty-panic story: the timing itself is not the lever, and the thing underneath it is partly modifiable, weight-neutrally and without alarm. It argues for steadiness, not surveillance, around a twelve-year-old's changing body.

The second finding points to the lever. A study in PLOS Global Public Health tracking nearly five thousand Swedish students aged twelve to sixteen over a year found that more screen time displaced sleep along several paths — and that the resulting rise in depressive symptoms showed up in girls, not boys.² If a parent defends one habit this year, the evidence says defend sleep: a protected bedtime, the phone charging outside the bedroom, a consistent wake time. It is unglamorous and it is the intervention with a girl-specific signal behind it. Both studies are correlational, and neither is Singaporean — a UK cohort and a Swedish one — so they are guidance, not diagnosis, and are labelled as such here.²

~6,600

YOUNG PEOPLE IN THE ALSPAC COHORT BEHIND THE PUBERTY-AND-BODY-IMAGE FINDING — WHERE THE LINK RAN LARGELY THROUGH BMI, NOT PUBERTAL TIMING ITSELF¹

Defend one habit this year, and the evidence says defend sleep — it is the lever with a girl-specific signal behind it.

THE SCEPTIC · DON'T BE ALARMIST — THE NAMED DISSENT

The moral-panic framing deserves its own cross-examination, and real researchers supply it. Candice Odgers of UC Irvine, reviewing Haidt's *Anxious Generation* in *Nature*, wrote that hundreds of researchers "have searched for the kind of large effects" the book claims and found "a mix of no, small and mixed associations." Amy Orben and Andrew Przybylski, across some three hundred and fifty-five thousand adolescents, put digital-tech use at roughly zero-point-four per cent of the variation in wellbeing — about the same as eating potatoes or wearing glasses. Chris Ferguson warns the alarmed "consensus" skewed as sceptics dropped out. The honest read: the population effect is real but small and concentrated — in lost sleep, in the age you start, in already-vulnerable kids — not a uniform catastrophe. Steady norms beat panic.³

Odgers in *Nature*; Orben & Przybylski in *Science*; Ferguson — characterised

THE TAKEAWAYS

Weight-neutral, not weight-focused. The puberty-body-image link runs through BMI; the play is calm, healthy routines, not comment on a changing body.¹

Bedroom, not bedtime alone. The phone out of the room is the sleep intervention with the girl-specific evidence behind it.²

Delay beats police. If the research points anywhere for a twelve-year-old, it is toward a later start, not tighter surveillance of an account she already has (p12).³

SOURCES 1. Tarif et al., BMJ Open 2025;15:e092212 (open access, ALSPAC cohort, n=6,644; Univ. of Bristol) — in girls, earlier menarche associated with higher body dissatisfaction at 14, effect substantially explained by BMI. Correlational; UK cohort. 2. PLOS Global Public Health, 2025 (journal.pgph.0004262); StatNews 25 Jun 2025 — Swedish students n=4,810, ages 12–16, 12 months; screen time displaced sleep, raising depressive symptoms in girls but not boys. Correlational; Swedish cohort. 3. Candice Odgers, review of J. Haidt's "The Anxious Generation," *Nature* (2024); Amy Orben & Andrew Przybylski, *Science* ("Unsettled science on social media," doi 10.1126/science.adr1730) — ~355,000 adolescents, digital-tech use ≈0.4% of wellbeing variance; Chris Ferguson (Stetson) on consensus skew. General guidance for parents, not medical advice.

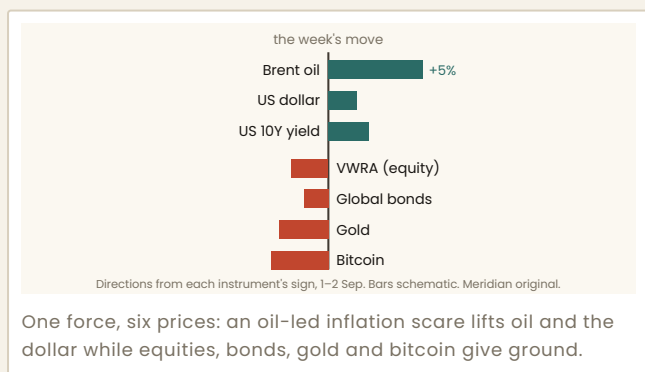
THE MACRO DESK · THE REGIME

Everything Falls but Oil and the Dollar

A Strait of Hormuz supply shock became an inflation scare, and money markets flipped from pricing a September cut to leaning toward a hike. The sharpest tell: gold at a multi-week low in the middle of a Middle East war.

The oil price wrote this week's macro story and rewrote the rate path with it. Brent jumped about five per cent to ninety-five dollars, a six-week high, as the strikes over Hormuz (p3) killed any hope of the channel normalising.¹ A supply shock is a headline-inflation impulse, and the market read it straight: money that had priced a September cut swung toward a hike, the US ten-year climbed to about four-point-eight per cent — its highest since November 2023 — and the dollar firmed. With rate expectations moving up, the four instruments this desk tracks fell together: global equities off, bonds soft as yields rose, gold at a multi-week low, and bitcoin down with them.²

The sharpest signal looks wrong: gold at a two-to-four-week low in an escalating Gulf war — because rising real yields, the cost of holding metal that pays nothing, are overwhelming the haven bid.³ Note the counterpoint the book closes on: while global gold slips on yields, Vietnam's savers pile into it as a currency of trust (p21) — the same metal, priced by a Western rate cycle and an Asian trust deficit at once. This is education, not advice; unverifiable numbers are held.³



INSTRUMENT	LEVEL (1-2 SEP)
VWRA (All-World)	~US\$193.4 ▼
Global bonds (AGGU)	~US\$5.82 ▼
Gold (spot)	~US\$4,355 ▼
Bitcoin	~US\$77k ▼

SOURCES 1. TradingEconomics; Bloomberg — Brent ~US\$95 (+~5%), six-week high, on the Hormuz strikes (p3). 2. stockanalysis.com (VWRA ~193.4); eToro/Bloomberg (AGGU ~5.82); TradingEconomics/CNBC (US 10Y ~4.79%, highest since Nov 2023; DXY ~99.85); Kalshi — markets swung from a September cut toward a hike. 3. FXStreet; Yahoo Finance (gold soft, 2-4-week low, real-yield-driven); CoinDesk (BTC ~US\$77k); Baird's Ross Mayfield (bond volatility the master variable); gold-bitcoin correlation negative in 2026. 4. Yahoo Finance/Investing (STI ~5,708; USD/JPY ~158.9); US BLS calendar (payrolls 5 Sep, consensus ~+125k); FOMC 15-16 Sep; BoJ 16-17 Sep; MAS ~14 Oct; US EIA (Mideast output not near pre-war until early 2027). Market data is context and education, not investment advice; unverifiable levels are held.

US 10-year	~4.79% ▲
US dollar (DXY)	~99.85 ▲
Brent crude	~US\$95 ▲
STI	~5,708 ▼

Levels around the 1-2 Sep 2026 close; ▲ / ▼ mark the move, not sentiment. Context, not advice.⁴

~4.79%

THE US 10-YEAR AT ITS HIGHEST SINCE NOVEMBER 2023 —
THE REAL-YIELD FORCE PRESSING ON ALL FOUR
INSTRUMENTS AT ONCE²

WHAT IT MEANS FOR VWRA, GLOBAL BONDS, GOLD & BTC

One force is pricing all four. An oil-driven inflation scare lifts real yields and the dollar, and that single move pressures equities, drags bond prices, caps gold despite the war, and knocks bitcoin as a risk proxy — the rare tape where geopolitics does not rescue the hedges. The equity-bond correlation is positive and unhelpful: both fell together, so a stocks-plus-bonds book got no cushion. Gold moves on real yields; bitcoin now tracks liquidity — their 2026 correlation has gone negative.

Baird (Ross Mayfield); CoinDesk; TradingEconomics — characterised

THE SCEPTIC · A POLICY-ERROR SETUP?

The hike panic may be the wrong read. An oil shock is a tax on growth, not demand-pull inflation — hiking into it risks deepening a slowdown. Friday's US payrolls are the hinge: a soft print could unwind the hike bets fast and hand gold and bonds a snap-back. Gold at multi-week lows while real yields sit at cycle highs is what contrarians watch for a reversal.

Macro-strategy commentary; EIA output timeline — characterised

ON THE CALENDAR

Fri 5 Sep — US payrolls (consensus ~+125k): the print that confirms or breaks the hike bet. Then US CPI (~10-11 Sep), the **15-16 Sep FOMC** (hike-vs-hold) and the **BoJ** the next day, a hike widely expected. MAS meets ~14 Oct.⁴

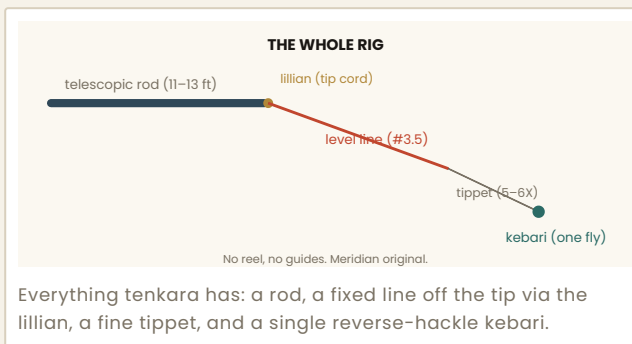
THE RABBIT HOLE · TENKARA FLY-FISHING

The Reel Is the Part You Take Away

A long telescopic rod, a line tied straight to the tip, one fly, no reel. Tenkara is the Japanese mountain-stream method that strips fly fishing back to a hand, a line and a fish — a whole hobby built on subtraction, and one that quietly grows a quiver anyway.

Start with what is missing. Tenkara is fixed-line fly fishing: a long telescopic carbon rod, usually eleven to thirteen feet, with a set length of line tied directly to the tip — no reel, no guides, no line to manage — a short piece of tippet, and most often a single wet fly.¹ Against Western fly fishing, the difference is the reel and the running line: there is no mending line through guides, no shooting line, no playing a fish off the drag, just a rod-length-plus-line of reach and a cast that still loads the rod and turns the line over. Against spin fishing, there is no weighted lure and no retrieve — you present a near-weightless fly and animate it with the rod itself. The whole kit fits in a jacket pocket.¹

The method is old and Japanese. It grew out of *keiryu* — mountain-stream — fishing in the 1800s, the working craft of the *shokuryōshi*, commercial anglers who fished remote headwaters for *yamame* and *iwana* to sell, and it survived as a semi-secret regional skill.² Japan rediscovered it as sport in the late 1970s and 1980s, led by figures the deep end still cites — Dr. Hisao Ishigaki, the "one-fly" populariser widely called the father of modern tenkara; Masami Sakakibara, known as "Tenkara no Oni," the demon of tenkara; and the headwaters explorer Yuzo Sebata.² The single dateable moment it crossed to the West is 2009, when Daniel Galhardo — Brazilian-born, a self-taught angler who quit banking — founded Tenkara USA, the first company to sell the rods outside Japan, pitching philosophy as hard as product: simplify, slow down, one rod, mountain streams.³



THE CHATTER · "IS IT EVEN FLY FISHING?"

The oldest fight in the room. Western purists periodically dismiss tenkara as "a fancy cane pole" or "dapping"; the tenkara camp insists it is genuine fly casting — you load the rod and turn the line over, just without the reel — and that "it is immediately recognizable as fly fishing." Honest insiders concede the reach and technique do overlap with high-stick dapping on the tiniest water. The argument never resolves, which is part of why the community enjoys it.

Tenkara USA "misconceptions"; r/tenkara; R&R Fly Fishing — characterised

THE SCEPTIC · HOW BIG IS THIS WORLD, REALLY?

Small, and honestly counted. Tenkara USA's founder will only say there are "more than a thousand but fewer than a million" US anglers; the biggest hub, the "Tenkara Anglers" Facebook group, sits around nine thousand. The one hard growth figure is a roughly forty-per-cent jump in new anglers in 2020. This is a niche, not a movement — which the map ahead makes its own kind of virtue.

Tenkara USA; Trout Unlimited; OPB Oregon Field Guide — characterised

WHAT THE NEXT TWO PAGES DESCEND INTO

The community & the gear — who gathers where, and the rods, lines and flies from a hundred-dollar starter to a Japanese master's own rod. p16

The craft & the money pit — the wooden net obsession, the jargon, the honest first ninety days, and where the "no-gear" hobby quietly becomes a quiver. p17

SOURCES 1. tenkarabum.com (fixed-line fly fishing); discovertenkara.com knowledge base — telescopic 11-13 ft rod, line tied to the tip via the lillian, tippet, single kebari; no reel/guides; rod-length-plus-line reach. 2. discovertenkara.com; Tenkara USA (history) — *keiryu* origins, 1800s written accounts, *shokuryōshi* commercial anglers (*yamame/iwana*); late-1970s-80s Japanese sport revival, Dr. Hisao Ishigaki (one-fly), Masami Sakakibara ("Tenkara no Oni"), Yuzo Sebata (*genryu*). 3. Tenkara USA "About"; midcurrent Q&A; OPB Oregon Field Guide — Daniel Galhardo founded Tenkara USA in 2009, first to sell tenkara rods outside Japan; ~40% jump in new tenkara anglers in 2020; "more than 1,000 but fewer than a million" US anglers; "Tenkara Anglers" FB group ~9,000; r/tenkara low thousands (figure stale/unverified live).

THE RABBIT HOLE • THE DEEP END

Where They Gather, and the Rods a Hundred Dollars to Three Buys

The community is small and opinionated, and the gear ladder runs from a hundred-dollar Shadowfire to a Japanese master's own rod. The through-line: a "no-reel" hobby with a surprisingly deep quiver at the top.

The map first. The de-facto hub is Tenkara Angler, Michael Agneta's magazine-and-community; the serious instruction comes from Discover Tenkara in the UK, where Paul Gaskell and John Pearson built masterclasses out of research trips to Japan. Chris Stewart's TenkaraBum is the gear brain and a retailer — the place to buy Japanese rods and fall down the technical hole; Teton Tenkara is the video-and-review archive; the 10 Colors forum is where the deep-enders argue, its name from the saying that for every ten anglers there are ten methods.¹ Tenkara Guides LLC in Utah runs the Oni School with Masami Sakakibara, and Zen Tenkara's Karin Miller pioneered the "big fish" faction. Troutbitten is the sceptical neighbour that supplies the movement's sharpest internal critic.¹

The running arguments are three: level line versus furred; Japanese purism versus Western adaptation — a flame war the community has learned to mock; and "warmwater tenkara," fixed-line rods for bass and panfish, embraced in the American East and dismissed by traditionalists who hold that tenkara is for mountain trout.¹

THE GEAR • RODS, BY HONEST TIER

The cheap floor is a line, not a ladder: a DRAGONtail Shadowfire 365 at about a hundred and ten dollars punches well above it, and the sub-fifty-dollar Amazon rods are a false economy the community warns off — tips break, no parts support.² The sweet spot is a fixed-length six-to-four rod: Tenkara USA's Hane at a hundred and sixty, whose no-questions warranty is a real reason to pay up, or its zoom Sato and Rhodo at two-fifty; Nissin's Air Stage around two hundred. The high end is where a buy-once reader lingers: Nissin's Zerosum, Suntech's Tenkarakyo 36F — the successor to the discontinued TenkaraBum 36, at a hundred and eighty — and the Daiwa Enshou at

around two-hundred-and-sixty. San Francisco's Tanuki, boutique high-modulus carbon, runs three hundred; one reviewer calls them the finest tenkara rods in the world, Japan included.²

7:3 • 6:4 • 5:5

ROD ACTIONS — WHERE THE ROD BENDS, TIP TO FULL — WITH A "PENNY RATING" (PENNIES TO DEFLECT THE TIP A THIRD OF ITS LENGTH) PUTTING A REAL NUMBER ON THE FLEX³

The endgame identity object is the Oni rod, Masami Sakakibara's own design — a Type III runs about thirty-four thousand yen, roughly two hundred and thirty dollars, with no US distributor, so you order direct and pay the import.² Line is simpler and cheaper: level line is straight fluorocarbon in sizes two-and-a-half to four-and-a-half — Sunline's Buttobi is the reference — denser than nylon, it cuts wind and holds off the water, the skilled choice; furred line is self-loading and the most forgiving for a beginner. Tippet is five-to-six-X, three or four feet off the end. And the fly is where the philosophy lives: the sakasa kebari, hackle swept forward to pulse when you move it, and Dr. Ishigaki's one-fly creed — he has fished essentially a single size-twelve pattern for years, on the argument that presentation beats selection.³

THE CHATTER • THE TIP, AND THE WARRANTY

The near-universal owner complaint is tip breakage — and the community is precise about it: the delicate tip snaps most often during setup and takedown near the lillian, not while fighting a fish, so you bury the tip while cinching the line. The other running theme is warranties as the real buy-once case: Tenkara USA ships replacement sections without demanding the rod back, which owners cite as worth the premium over a cheaper rod with no parts support.

Tenkara USA "rod breakages"; Minimalist Gear Co; r/tenkara — characterised

SOURCES 1. tenkaraangler.com (Michael Agneta; hub); discovertenkara.com (Gaskell & Pearson); tenkarabum.com (Chris Stewart); tetontenkara.blogspot.com; discourse.10colorstenkara.com; tenkaraguides.com (Oni School, Sakakibara); zentenkara.com (Karin Miller, big-fish faction); troutbitten.com — community map and the level-vs-furred / purism / warmwater arguments. 2. DRAGONtail (Shadowfire 365 —US\$110); Tenkara USA (Hane \$160, Sato/Rhodo \$250, Ito \$260); Nissin (Air Stage ~\$186–235, Zerosum ~\$196–258); Suntech Tenkarakyo 36F "TenkaraBum" (~\$170–185, successor to the discontinued TenkaraBum 36); Daiwa Enshou LL36S-F ~\$226; Tanuki Ninja 350 ~\$300 (Frank Burr review); Oni rod Type III ~¥33,979 (~US\$230, no US distributor) — retailer/maker listings, current Sep 2026 (USD; verify at purchase). 3. tenkaratalk.com (7:3/6:4/5:5 actions; Common Cents "penny" system); Sunline Buttobi level line (#2.5–#4.5), furred vs level; tippet 5–6X; sakasa kebari (reverse hackle); Dr. Hisao Ishigaki's one-fly (size-12) creed.

THE RABBIT HOLE · THE CRAFT, AND THE MONEY PIT

The Net That Takes a Year, and the Quiver a "No-Gear" Hobby Grows

At the top, tenkara stops being about fish and starts being about objects — a hand-bent wooden net with a twelve-month wait. The honest first ninety days cost about a hundred and thirty dollars. The honest endgame has no ceiling at all.

The craft object the deep end genuinely lusts after is the tamo — the traditional landing net, a single Y-shaped branch trained over years into a teardrop hoop, classically from rare kaya wood. The revered makers have names: Mankyu, whose nets are "gorgeous and rightfully expensive," and Yukihiro Yoshimura, who taught Galhardo. A Mankyu tamo runs about a hundred and sixty-seven to three hundred dollars, a premium piece near six hundred; a bespoke Western net means a deposit and a twelve-month wait.¹ A twenty-dollar net lands fish just as well — the whole tell about where this hobby goes.

The cutting edge is real but modest. Suntech discontinued its beloved Kurenai HM for the Kurenai II "AR" line this cycle; its Tenkarakyo 36F was reviewed in May 2026, a Tanuki Wabi 360 prototype surfaced in August 2025, and the Oni Type-II drew a February 2026 review. The budget floor keeps dropping while Japanese premiums hold at two to three hundred — but there is no headline flagship in the last sixty days, and the desk will not invent one.¹

THE GLOSSARY · SPEAKING TENKARA

kebari the fly · **sakasa kebari** reverse-hackle fly · **tamo** wooden landing net · **keiryu** mountain stream · **genryu** remote headwaters · **seiryu** light clear-stream rod · **level line** untapered fluorocarbon · **lillian** the tip cord the line ties to · **zoom** a rod telescoping to two or three lengths · **penny rating** stiffness in pennies to bend the tip · **Oni** Masami Sakakibara, "the demon of tenkara." **tenkarabum.com**; **discovertenkara.com** — **glossary**

\$130 → ∞

A CURIOUS STARTER IS ~\$110–130 ALL-IN; COMMITTED ~\$300–400; THE DEEP END ~\$600–1,000+; THE COLLECTOR'S QUIVER HAS NO CEILING²

THE FIRST NINETY DAYS

Lurk before spending. Read TenkaraBum and Discover Tenkara's free guides and learn the setup-and-takedown ritual before you own a rod — it prevents the number-one breakage.²

Buy the sensible kit (~\$110–130). A DRAGONtail Shadowfire complete kit or a Tenkara USA Hane — a fixed-length six-to-four rod, not a zoom.²

Then go deeper. The 10 Colors forum for gear, a regional meet-up, and — if hooked — one premium rod, not three cheap ones. Gatherings: the Oni School in Utah, the Appalachian Tenkara Jam.²

THE SCEPTIC · THE ANTI-GEAR HOBBY THAT GROWS A QUIVER

The sharpest critique comes from a neighbour: Troutbitten's "The Trouble With Tenkara" argues everything tenkara does well can be done as well or better with a long fly rod and a tight-line "Mono Rig," and that the celebrated limitation — no reel, forced to fish close — is a weakness dressed as virtue. Wind, big rivers and big fish expose the fixed line. And the money-pit paradox is the community's own joke: a hobby sold as anti-gear becomes rod-collecting and the tamo habit — bespoke nets at six hundred dollars, year-long waits, that catch no more fish than a twenty-dollar one. Devotees swear the Oni is worth it; pragmatists note a hundred-and-sixty-dollar Hane catches the same trout. Both are right; that is the tell.

Troutbitten (Domenick Swentosky, "The Trouble With Tenkara"); r/tenkara; 10 Colors — characterised

NEXT DESCENTS — YOU PICK THE NEXT HOBBY

Home espresso — the definitive buy-once money pit, where a \$300 machine becomes a \$3,000 grinder-and-puck-prep rabbit hole, and the community never agrees on the endgame.

Mechanical keyboards — group buys, artisan keycaps and custom builds; deep gear tiers, vocal factions, and an "endgame" that keeps moving.

Birding — the low-floor counterpoint, binoculars to \$2,500 scopes to a global "big year," and Singapore genuinely world-class at Sungei Buloh.

SOURCES 1. tenkaratalk.com (Mankyu tamo review; kaya wood; Yukihiro Yoshimura); US-importer listings (Mankyu keiryu tamo ~\$167–308, premium ~\$595; Tenkara USA "The TAMO" \$140; bespoke maple ~\$320 + deposit + up to 12-month wait); tenkaraangler.com (Suntech Kurenai II "AR" replacing the discontinued Kurenai HM; Tenkarakyo 36F review May 2026; Tanuki Wabi 360 prototype Aug 2025; Oni Type-II review Feb 2026). No verified headline flagship in the last 60 days — not invented. 2. tenkarabum.com; discovertenkara.com (setup/takedown ritual; furling — #3.5 level line; sakasa kebari + Killer Bug, size 12); economics ~\$110–130 starter / ~\$300–400 committed / ~\$600–1,000+ deep; gatherings — Oni School (Utah), Appalachian Tenkara Jam, Colorado Tenkara Camp (25–28 Sep 2026), Women's Tenkara Gathering (10–13 Sep 2026).

FITNESS • THE MARKER QUESTION

Grip Strength Predicts How Long You Live — but It Is a Marker, Not a Lever

A new study ties a firm handshake and a fast chair-rise to a third lower death risk. The catch is the one the honest reader should hold onto: the strength is the signal that you are robust, not the switch that makes you so.

The headline finding this cycle is a clean one, and its caveat is cleaner. A study in JAMA Network Open, led by Michael LaMonte at the University at Buffalo using the Women's Health Initiative cohort, followed more than five thousand women aged sixty-three to ninety-nine for about eight years and found that those in the highest grip-strength group had roughly a third lower all-cause mortality than the lowest — with each standard-deviation rise in grip worth about twelve per cent, and a faster five-times sit-to-stand similarly protective.¹ The researchers adjusted for physical activity, inflammation and cardiovascular fitness to isolate the strength signal. The honest limits: it is observational, the population is women over sixty, and it is exposed to reverse causation — undiagnosed illness lowers strength and raises death risk at once. This is general guidance, not medical advice.¹

The second finding flatters the wearable crowd and deserves its asterisk. A paper in Scientific Reports surveyed three hundred and forty lifelong multi-marathoners — mean age fifty-two, an average of a hundred and twenty-one marathons each — and estimated their VO2 max from wearables, finding it well above age norms with a shallower decline.² But no deaths were tracked; the mortality benefit is modelled from earlier data, the sample is self-selected and self-reported, and the VO2 numbers are wearable estimates. It is hypothesis-generating, not proof that chasing a VO2 score buys years.²

~33%

LOWER ALL-CAUSE MORTALITY IN THE STRONGEST-GRIP GROUP VS THE WEAKEST, OVER ~8 YEARS — ASSOCIATION, IN WOMEN 63–99, NOT A PROMISE THAT A GRIPPER EXTENDS LIFE¹

SOURCES 1. LaMonte et al., "Muscular Strength and Mortality in Women Aged 63 to 99 Years," JAMA Network Open, Feb 2026 (Women's Health Initiative cohort, n>5,000, ~8-yr follow-up); University at Buffalo press release, Feb 2026; CNN health, 23 Mar 2026 — highest grip group ~33% lower all-cause mortality, ~12% per SD, faster 5x sit-to-stand similarly protective, adjusted for activity/inflammation/CV fitness. Observational; women 63–99; reverse-causation caveat. 2. "VO2 max in lifelong multi-marathon runners," Scientific Reports (Nature portfolio), 2026 (n=340, mean age 52.2, avg 121 marathons; wearable-estimated VO2 max above FRIEND age norms, shallower decline). No deaths tracked — mortality benefit modelled, not observed; cross-sectional, self-selected, self-reported. General wellness information, not medical advice; consult your clinician/trainer before changing a program.

The strength is the signal that you are robust — not the switch that makes you so.

THE CHATTER • "KEEP LIFTING," NOT "BUY A GRIPPER"

The longevity-and-fitness commentary reads these findings the sensible way: grip strength is a by-product of serious full-body resistance training, not a target to isolate. Writing in The Conversation, researchers put it plainly — improving your grip in isolation won't make you healthier or extend your life. The takeaway is "keep lifting and keep an aerobic base," not "train the handshake."

The Conversation; r/Fitness longevity discourse — characterised

THE SCEPTIC • DON'T OVERCLAIM THE CAUSATION

Grip strength predicts mortality about as well as systolic blood pressure — but prediction is not causation. It flags who is frail or ill, which inflates the observational link through reverse causation and healthy-user bias. Neither study shows that adding grip work, or hitting a VO2 target, makes you live longer. The defensible read is the dull, durable one from last issue: resistance training plus an aerobic base, around the ninety-to-a-hundred-and-twenty-minutes-a-week strength dose — the handshake comes along for the ride.

The Conversation; BJSM meta-analysis (No.90) — characterised

THE PRACTICAL LINE

Train the body, read the marker. Compound lifts build the grip the studies measure; don't buy a device to game a signal.¹

VO2 is a dial, not a verdict. A rising number on the Oura or Whoop is a good sign of aerobic base — not evidence, by itself, of years added.²

THE DIARY · THE DATED AGENDA

A Padang Full of Headliners, and a Fukuoka Basho to Book the Flights Around

The Grand Prix brings the strongest concert bill the Padang has carried — Lana Del Rey's first Singapore show among them — and Japan's autumn stacks a sold-out Tokyo basho, an Orsay blockbuster and the last of the leaves.

SINGAPORE

BOOK NOW · PLAN AHEAD

7 OCT **Hans Zimmer Live** — Indoor Stadium. Dune, Interstellar, the Lion King; a family-friendly film-score night. CONCERT · S\$148–468

9–11 OCT **★ F1 Singapore Grand Prix — first-ever Sprint** — Marina Bay Street Circuit. Sprint on Saturday; the city turns festival, hotels tight. SPORT · THE MARQUEE

10–11 OCT **★ The Killers & Lana Del Rey** — Padang Stage. Lana's first Singapore show; a race ticket is the key (from the ~S\$198 Walkabout). CONCERT · NEEDS F1 TICKET

29 Oct–15 Nov **CATS the Musical** — Sands Theatre, MBS. Weekend matinees; the family booking of the season. THEATRE · FAMILY

10–11 Nov **My Chemical Romance** — Indoor Stadium, two nights. Rescheduled from April; largely sold out. CONCERT

JAPAN & THE REGION

PLAN THE FLIGHTS

to 8 Oct **teamLab Borderless** — Azabudai Hills, Tokyo. Timed tickets ahead; teamLab Planets is the family site. ART · TOKYO

16 Oct–2 Nov **Sculpture by the Sea, Bondi** — Sydney's 30th, a hundred-plus works, free; worth an Australia hop. ART · SYDNEY

8–22 NOV **★ Kyushu Basho (Grand Sumo)** — Fukuoka. On sale 19 Sep; good seats gone in hours. SPORT · FUKUOKA

from Nov **Masterworks from the Musée d'Orsay** — Tokyo Metropolitan Art Museum. ~110 works incl. Van Gogh; the autumn blockbuster. ART · TOKYO

20 Nov–5 Dec **Autumn leaves (kōyō)** — Kyoto peaks late Nov, Tokyo into early Dec; time the flights for the month's last third. SEASON · JAPAN

PLANNING NOTES

F1: a race ticket is the door to the Padang — cheapest route is the ~S\$198 Walkabout; book hotels for 2–11 Oct. **Sumo:** Kyushu on sale 19 Sep. **Family (12):** Hans Zimmer, CATS, teamLab; F1 is loud.

THE CHATTER · THE STRONGEST PADANG BILL YET

The pull is Lana Del Rey's first Singapore show on Sunday race night, The Killers back after roughly eight years, and JJ Lin anchoring the Friday — read by press and fans as one of the best Grand Prix bills the city has staged. The counter-note is cost: you must buy into the race, and Lana-facing tickets start around three hundred and sixty-eight dollars.

singaporegp.sg; Bandwagon; press coverage — characterised

SETTING THE RECORD STRAIGHT

No. 90 listed Coldplay at Tokyo Dome as a 5–6 September marquee. That is wrong: 5 September is the on-sale date, and the Tokyo show is in January 2027 — a 2027 trip to plan, not a September ticket. The desk corrects it here.

coldplay.com / Live Nation listings

SOURCES 1. singaporegp.sg (F1 Singapore GP 9–11 Oct 2026, first Sprint; Padang Stage — The Killers 10 Oct, Lana Del Rey 11 Oct, JJ Lin 9 Oct; Zone 4 Walkabout ~S\$198); Sports Hub (Hans Zimmer 7 Oct); MBS/SISTIC (CATS 29 Oct–15 Nov); SISTIC/Bandwagon (My Chemical Romance 10–11 Nov). 2. Nihon Sumo Kyokai (Kyushu Basho 8–22 Nov, on sale 19 Sep; Aki Basho sold out); teamLab official (Borderless to 8 Oct); Tokyo Metropolitan Art Museum (Orsay, from Nov); Japan foliage forecasts (kōyō ~20 Nov–5 Dec); sculpturebythesea.com (Bondi, 16 Oct–2 Nov). Coldplay correction: coldplay.com / Live Nation — 5 Sep is the on-sale, the Tokyo show is Jan 2027.

THE DIARY • THE TABLE

A Starred Chef Goes Rustic, and a Straits House Opens in the Botanic Gardens

Three genuinely new Singapore openings worth the trip — a Michelin-starred Italian doing a deliberately imperfect set menu, a garden dining house of borderless Straits cooking, and a Tokyo sushi counter relocated to a hinoki room.

The most credentialed opening of the month is the most relaxed. Assaggi, on Neil Road, is the new room from Denis Lucchi, who has held a Michelin star at Buona Terra since 2019; here he cooks "imperfect by choice" — rustic, ingredient-led, deliberately less formal than a starred pass. It runs on set menus only: a fifty-eight-dollar three-course lunch, and dinner tasting menus, the Signature and the Pasta, at eighty-eight, all before service and tax.¹ The early consensus across the food press frames it as the smart way to eat a starred chef's cooking without fine-dining spend; the honest caveats are that it is set-menu-only, with no à la carte, and still too new for a settled verdict. The room is small — book ahead. Not halal.

Tembusu, in the Botanic Gardens' Ginger Garden, opens officially today after a soft launch in early August. It is a "borderless Straits" dining house from the Fleursophy group — Malay, Peranakan and wider Southeast Asian flavours with a light modern hand — and its hook is setting and mood: cottagecore meets Straits maximalism, pet-friendly indoors, tucked in the greenery.² Signatures run to a Tembusu nasi lemak, a squid-ink claypot rice with abalone, an udon laksa, and kaya toast with Nanyang kopi. Early write-ups praise the renovation, the garden and the warm service — very much an experience play, so the food is too new to call. Weekend brunch will queue; reserve. Assume not halal-certified.

For a special occasion, Sushi Ryujiro reopened in July inside the Capitol Kempinski — the Singapore counter of Tokyo's Michelin-starred Ryujiro Nakamura, now in a new ten-seat hinoki room, seafood flown from Japan four times a week.³ Omakase runs from a two-hundred-and-twenty-eight-dollar nigiri lunch to a four-hundred-and-twenty-eight-dollar dinner, all before service and

tax. The reputation is for technical precision; with ten seats it is hard to book. Present it honestly as new premises rather than a new concept. Not halal.

SET-MENU ITALIAN

GARDEN STRAITS

TOKYO OMAKASE

THE BUZZ • WHAT THE FOOD PRESS IS SAYING

Across the local food media — HungryGoWhere, Ordinary Patrons, The Ranting Panda — Assaggi is read as the value story of the batch, a starred chef's cooking at bistro spend, with the set-menu-only format the one reservation. Tembusu is landing as an ambience destination first, its Straits menu unproven; Sushi Ryujiro carries its Tokyo star into a harder-to-book room. Two of the three are weeks old, so the desk reads their verdicts as provisional.

HungryGoWhere; Ordinary Patrons; The Ranting Panda — characterised

THE SCEPTIC • "TOO NEW TO CALL" MEANS TOO NEW TO CALL

Two of these opened within the month, and an opening is not a verdict. A garden setting and a warm soft-launch generate the first wave of praise reliably, before the kitchen has found its consistency or the queue its patience — the honest move is to note the anticipation and hold the judgement, not to launder buzz into a review. Assaggi's set-menu format is the real trade-off to weigh: you are buying the chef's choice, not your own. The desk flags all three as provisional and invents no praise it cannot source.

Food-media soft-launch coverage — characterised

THE BASICS

Assaggi — Neil Road, Tanjong Pagar · set menus S\$58 lunch / S\$88 dinner ++ · book ahead.¹

Tembusu — Ginger Garden, Botanic Gardens · à la carte, garden setting · reserve for weekend brunch.²

Sushi Ryujiro — Capitol Kempinski · omakase S\$228–428 ++ · ten seats, book early.³

SOURCES 1. HungryGoWhere; Ordinary Patrons — Assaggi (Neil Road), chef Denis Lucchi (one Michelin star at Buona Terra since 2019), opened 10 Aug 2026, "imperfect by choice," set menus only (S\$58 3-course lunch; Signature / Pasta dinner tasting S\$88, ++); too new for a settled verdict; not halal. 2. HungryGoWhere; Ordinary Patrons; The Ranting Panda — Tembusu (Ginger Garden, Singapore Botanic Gardens), Fleursophy group, "borderless Straits," soft-launched early Aug, official open 3 Sep 2026; nasi lemak, squid-ink claypot with abalone, udon laksa, kaya toast; ambience-led, food too new to call; assume not halal-certified. 3. Local dining coverage — Sushi Ryujiro (Capitol Kempinski Hotel), Tokyo Michelin-starred chef Ryujiro Nakamura, reopened 15 Jul 2026, new 10-seat hinoki counter, seafood flown from Japan 4x/week; omakase S\$228 (nigiri lunch) / S\$298 (lunch) / S\$428 (dinner), ++; new premises rather than a new concept; not halal. Buzz summarised in the desk's own words; no reviews or quotes invented; the two newest venues flagged provisional.

THE LONG READ · THE UNDERCURRENT — VIETNAM

The People's Gold Goes Digital

Hanoi has finally torn down its gold monopoly and dreams of drawing the nation's five hundred tonnes of private gold into the banks. At the same moment, a generation is doing the opposite — putting more away, gram by gram, on payday, through apps and a sixty-five-thousand-member Facebook group. The state keeps asking for its gold back. The young have already answered.

On the eve of the God of Wealth Day this January, the queues outside the gold shops on Hanoi's Trần Nhân Tông Street began before dawn. By half past nine the flagship counters had sold out of rings and silver bars, and the benchmark price set by the state minter, Saigon Jewelry Company, had touched a record near a hundred and ninety-six million dong a tael — the old thirty-seven-and-a-half-gram unit that predates the modern currency.¹ The scene looked like tradition, and it was. What was new stood behind it, on the phones of the people still in line: Facebook resale groups tens of thousands strong, payday videos, and apps that will sell you gold in slices of a hundred thousand dong, about four US dollars.¹

The numbers under the queue are large. Vietnamese households are estimated to hold four to five hundred tonnes of gold — roughly thirty-five to forty billion dollars, about eight per cent of the country's output, more than the official reserves of many central banks, most of it in home safes.² And it has paid to hoard: domestic gold has risen about eighty-four per cent since early 2025, outpacing the roughly sixty-two per cent gain in the world price, with the local premium over the global rate running near five hundred and eighty dollars an ounce.² Into that run has stepped a generation that, on the surface, looks admirably disciplined — young office workers setting aside a few grams a month, copying grandmothers who never trusted a bank.

The grandmother's gold ring has become the app balance. The hedge survived; only the medium changed.

The savers are real, and named in the local press. An office worker of twenty-eight who started buying when gold looked like the one dependable channel; a twenty-six-year-old who buys one to five grams every month; a twenty-year-old setting aside what she can, copying her grandmother.³ In Hà Tĩnh, young workers describe putting away two to four million dong a month in metal. It reads as a wholesome habit. Read a layer down, it is something sharper — a quiet, inherited vote of no confidence in the dong, in banks still shadowed by the bond scandals of 2022, and in a state whose promises about currency stability the young have learned to discount. This desk's argument is that the two forces now pulling on Vietnam's gold — a government that wants it in the system, a generation that keeps it out — are the real story of the country's growth ambition, and that the generation is winning.³

~8%

OF VIETNAM'S GDP ESTIMATED TO SIT IN HOUSEHOLD GOLD — FOUR TO FIVE HUNDRED TONNES, MOSTLY IN HOME SAFES, THE COMPOUNDED INTEREST ON DECADES OF DEVALUATION²

The ritual is old enough to have its own units and calendar. Vietnam still prices gold in taels — the *lượng*, thirty-seven and a half grams, older than the modern dong — and buying peaks on the God of Wealth Day, when shops open before dawn.¹ What has changed is the interface: the buyer who once waited for a shopfront now watches a price alert, joins a resale group, and tops up an app balance from a payday transfer — the hedge intact, the medium modern.

A savings instinct older than the modern dong, ported onto Facebook and a fintech rail.

SOURCES 1. vietnamnet.vn; vietnam.vn; VnExpress, Jan–Feb 2026 — SJC gold at a record ~VND196 million/tael on 29 Jan 2026 (God of Wealth Day / Vía Thần Tài); Trần Nhân Tông St queues from before dawn, flagship shops sold out of rings by ~09:30; tael = 37.5 g (~1.2 troy oz); Facebook resale groups and digital-gold apps from ~VND100,000 (~US\$4). 2. SCMP; vietnamnews.vn; bullionstar.com — household gold estimated 400–500 tonnes (~US\$35–40bn, ~8% of GDP; economist Nguyễn Trí Hiếu / govt auditors); domestic gold ~+84% since early 2025 vs ~+62% global; local premium ~US\$580/oz (early Feb 2026); global gold above US\$5,000/oz (Jan 2026). 3. vietnamnews.vn, "Traditional asset finds new fans among the young," Feb 2026 (syndicated via The Star); vietnam.vn — named young buyers (Phan Thị Minh Anh, 28; Nguyễn Thị Thu Trang, 26, 1–5 g/month; Trần Thị Yến Nhi, 20); Hà Tĩnh workers VND2–4m/month; context of the 2022 bond scandals. Figures as reported.

THE LONG READ · THE MACHINERY

A Monopoly Falls, and the Trade Routes Around the State

To see why this matters, follow the policy. In 2011 and 2012, dong instability and fears of "goldisation" drove Hanoi to hand Saigon Jewelry Company the sole legal right to mint gold bars, freezing private gold into home safes and turning an ordinary metal into a state-stamped one.¹ For thirteen years an SJC bar could cost hundreds of dollars more than identical gold abroad, purely because one company held the die — a patriotism premium paid by anyone who wanted the trusted stamp. Then, on 10 October 2025, Decree 232 abolished the monopoly and let licensed banks and enterprises mint bars again. Day one, the shelves were empty.¹

Liberalisation collided with a price spike and a generation that had already gone around the shops entirely. Amid the shortage, gold now changes hands in Facebook groups sixty-five thousand members strong, dozens of posts a day; one seller moved five taels of gold rings at eighty-eight million dong each, about one per cent over the official price, with sellers typically listing a million or three above market.² The deputy chair of the Vietnam Gold Traders Association, Huỳnh Trung Khánh, warned it risks becoming "a black market" where "the quality of the gold they buy is not guaranteed."² Alongside the resale groups sit the fintechs — HanaGold selling accumulation from a hundred thousand dong, OGold pitching "smart gold savings" — though users have reported apps that locked withdrawals, a reminder that a digital claim on gold is not the same as gold.²

The state's answer is to try to borrow the hoard. Since late 2025, officials have floated schemes to "mobilise the people's gold" — gold-borrowing from households, gold-for-property swaps — to fund an eight-per-cent growth ambition, and the prime minister has ordered a National Gold Exchange fast-tracked, moving in phases from imported gold to bars to certificates and derivatives.³ But the same month, Vietnam recognised crypto as property, closing one grey escape hatch even as gold stayed king; and on 21 September the country's upgrade to emerging-market status takes effect, offering a competing, more volatile home for savings.³ The generation is unmoved. Deposits pay four to eight per cent; gold ran eighty-four. The instinct is not to lend the metal to a bank — it is to buy another gram.

4–8% vs 84%

A ONE-YEAR BANK DEPOSIT AGAINST GOLD'S RUN SINCE EARLY 2025 — THE RETURN GAP THAT MAKES "LEND US YOUR GOLD" A HARD SELL TO A SCEPTICAL GENERATION³

The risk sits on the buyer, not the state. A digital claim on gold is only as good as the company holding the metal behind it, and the same reports that celebrate young savers also carry the warnings: resale groups where purity is unverified, apps that have locked withdrawals, a premium that can evaporate if the price turns. The generation has swapped the counterparty risk of a bank it distrusts for the counterparty risk of a fintech it has not yet learned to — a trade that looks like prudence and is, for now, a bet.²

WHY THEY HOARD — GAIN SINCE EARLY 2025



nestic gold outran the world price; the local premium ran ~US\$580/oz. Meridian original; sources per footnote

Vietnamese domestic gold outpaced the world price — the return that turned a cultural habit into a financial one.

The state wants the gold in the system. The young want it on their phone. Only one of them is compounding.

SOURCES 1. bullionstar.com; vietnamnews.vn; Reuters/Bloomberg background — Decree 24 (2011–12) making SJC the sole bar minter after dong/"goldisation" turmoil; the multi-year SJC premium over world gold; Decree 232/2025/ND-CP (in force 10 Oct 2025) abolishing the 13-year monopoly, licensing banks/enterprises to mint bars; empty shelves on day one. 2. VnExpress, "Shortage sparks brisk gold trade on social media," 2026 — Facebook resale groups 65,000+ members; a sale of five taels of rings at VND88m each (~1.14% over SJC), sellers listing VND1–3m over market; Huỳnh Trung Khánh (Vietnam Gold Traders Association) — "a black market," quality "not guaranteed"; HanaGold (from VND100,000) and OGold digital accumulation; reported app withdrawal locks. 3. Bloomberg (mobilisation drive, 7 Nov 2025); VietnamNet — "mobilise the people's gold" proposals (gold-borrowing, gold-for-property) toward an 8% growth goal; PM order to fast-track a National Gold Exchange (phased: imported gold → bars → certificates/derivatives); Law on Digital Technology Industry recognising crypto as property (1 Jan 2026); FTSE emerging-market upgrade effective 21 Sep 2026; bank deposit rates ~4.1–7.8%.

THE LONG READ · THE ARGUMENT

The State Asks for Its Gold Back. The Generation Has Already Answered.

This is not the first time a nation's young have hedged their future in metal, and the precedents tell Hanoi how its plan ends. In China across 2023 and 2024, amid deflation, a property slump and youth unemployment, Gen-Z buyers hoarded one-gram gold "beans" at about eighty-three dollars each, kept in jars; the Weibo topic asking why young people were buying gold drew ninety-one million views.¹ Vietnam is running the same script one country south — and the Western press already wrote China's version, which is exactly why Vietnam's is the next one, not the last one. The behaviour is regional and generational: gold as the sober, grandmother-approved hedge for a cohort that finds property unreachable, equities thin, and crypto too new to trust.

The mobilisation dream has a precedent too, and it is a cautionary one. India, whose households and temples hold an estimated twenty-five to thirty-five thousand tonnes, launched a Gold Monetisation Scheme in 2015 to draw idle gold into the banking system. In eight or nine years it mobilised only around thirty tonnes — a fraction of a per cent — defeated by emotional attachment, a derisory interest rate, and the fact that deposited gold was melted down.¹ That is very likely the fate awaiting Vietnam's "mobilise the people's gold" proposals: a state can legalise a market far more easily than it can talk a grandmother out of her rings. And Vietnam has done this dance before — the 2011 monopoly it is now dismantling was itself a response to an earlier gold-and-dollar flight, proof that this is a recurring negotiation between a state that wants control of savings and a public that keeps opting out into metal.²

A state can legalise a market far more easily than it can talk a grandmother out of her rings.

So who wins, and what does it mean? In the near term the winners are the newly licensed minters — the banks, and jewellers like PNJ and DOJI — the gold shops, the digital-gold fintechs, and the disciplined young savers, so long as the price holds. The losers are the dong and the deposit-hungry banks; the mobilisation dream; and the naïve buyers exposed to unregulated Facebook trades, fake purity, and apps that freeze. The deeper meaning is the uncomfortable one for a country selling an eight-per-cent growth story: distrust is being modernised, not outgrown. The hedge survives; only the medium upgrades, from the safe to the app. Financialisation is routing around the state rather than through it — the same instinct that drives social commerce and the crypto the law has just had to recognise. And eight per cent of GDP asleep in home safes is the compounded interest on decades of devaluation, a trust deficit sitting at the base of the growth story.²

A regulated National Gold Exchange and formal digital-gold accounts could, in time, finally intermediate this instinct — give the generation a trusted rail that runs through the system instead of around it. Or a sharp correction in the gold price delivers a brutal lesson to a cohort that has only ever seen it rise. Either way, the punchline holds. The government keeps asking for its gold back; the generation has already answered, and the answer is no — but now it's on my phone.²

SOURCES 1. Bloomberg; Nikkei Asia (Mar 2024) — China's Gen-Z "gold beans" (~1 g, ~US\$83), the Weibo topic "why are young people buying gold" ~91m views. Business Standard; India Ministry of Finance — India's Gold Monetisation Scheme (2015): households/temples hold ~25,000–34,600 t; ~31–39 t mobilised in 8–9 years (~0.16%), defeated by attachment, a ~0.5% rate and melted deposits. 2. bullionstar.com; VietnamNet; SCMP — Vietnam's 2011–12 Decree 24 monopoly as a response to earlier gold/dollar flight (the cycle now unwinding via Decree 232); winners/losers of liberalisation (licensed minters, PNJ/DOJI, gold shops, fintechs vs the dong, deposit-hungry banks, the mobilisation plan, exposed retail buyers); the National Gold Exchange and digital-gold accounts as the possible formal intermediation. Analysis and argument; platform sentiment summarised as reported, not invented.

THE LAST WORD

On What Backs the Promise

Greenspan opened the book, and every desk turned out to be about the same question: what actually stands behind the thing you are handed. Singapore will bless a private stablecoin only if a real dollar sits behind each token, earning the holder nothing — because a promise of money is only as good as its reserve. A generation of Vietnamese, unconvinced by the dong, backs its savings with metal, and now buys it by the gram on an app while the state pleads for the hoard. The market spends a week deciding the dollar is better backed than gold, and gold falls in the middle of a war. A towel is backed by the length of its cotton, not the weight of its pile; a grip is a marker of a strong body, not the thing that makes one; a smart-glass sells the sensor it refuses to carry; and tenkara throws away the reel to trust the hand. The reader's whole discipline, from the belt to the balance sheet, is the unglamorous habit of asking what is behind the claim — and remembering that the loudest promises are usually the ones with the least behind them.

CONSOLIDATED SOURCES

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